To Survivors Everywhere – A Collection

By Sierra DeMulder

Taxidermy

Five years after your daughter's death,

you still cry in the juniors' section of department stores.

You preserve her bedroom like a taxidermist.

Her unworn prom dress still hangs

like a skinned mermaid in her closet.

Cancer entered your home like a greedy tenant,

drew himself into family portraits,

slept in your daughter's bed,

swallowed all her blood cells.

INTRODUCTION

The loss of a child may be the worst trauma a human being can experience. Though it's not a terribly common experience in the United States — about 10,000 children between the ages of 1 and 14 died in 2018 — the horrific potential for losing a child looms large. And although reassuring, the numbers also make plain why the death of a

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child brings so much grief, and why it's so feared, so painful, and so stigmatized.

To Survivors Everywhere – A Collection by Sierra DeMulder including Taxidermy, Misplacing Their Ring Fingers and Today Means Amen.

It started with a headache. A fever,

your daughter melting like a popsicle.

It took you a week to tell your husband

about the blood in the toilet.

Sometimes, you wonder

if you never caught it,

could you have lived

as if it was never there?

As if saying that word instantly

drapes a shroud over your house.

Would it still have slept

like cremation in her bed?

The doctors spoke to you in time lines,

as your daughter's weight dropped like a countdown,

a surprise party no one wanted to throw.

EDUCATIONAL

Once, when she was in the other room,
her blood being read like tea leaves,
the doctor suggested not to bother with college
applications.

You couldn't bring yourself to tell her.
You couldn't bring yourself to say it.
Sometimes you think she knew,
as she methodically filled out each question and box,
it was never for her.

There is still a stack of unsent applications
hidden like tumor in your dresser.
She kissed every envelope goodbye.
You couldn't bear to send more of her away.

When she passed,
quietly like a note to God,
all you wanted was to swaddle her
in your arms like an infant, bring her home
from the hospital, fragile and new.

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Breastfeed her back to life,
potty train and finger paint,
reteach her the alphabet,
retrace her first steps
back to you.

To lose a child is like giving birth in reverse.
It is slow and it rips, planting a permanent lump
in your throat.

When chemotherapy pulled out
the last of her hair, you started carrying
her baby teeth in your pocket: A reminder
things can grow back.

TRANSITION

*And it's true . . . some things **can** grow back, but so many other things fall apart.*

Misplacing Their Ring Fingers

The summer my parents lost their marriage
like so many magnets kicked under the refrigerator,
my cousin and I named trees after babysitters
we never had. We lived in our bathing suits,
washed our hair in pond water and sunburned.

(Once, my mother slammed the screen
door so hard, I comforted the hinges.) I taught
my cousin how to make face paint out of spit
and dirt. She taught me to swim underwater.
(Once, I found my father weeping on the bed
they did not share anymore.) On the green carpet
of summer, we played until the cicadas, dressed
in dusk, called us to dinner. We kissed goodnight
and I ran home barefoot in the dark.

(Once, I sat between my parents and placed their hands
in my lap like a seatbelt. I do not remember this.)
To this day, walking at night on that creaking road
still reminds me of wolves.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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TRANSITION

So how do people survive so much pain, so much loss? Some people understandably crumble after traumatic events, while others seem to have an extraordinary capacity to rebound and survive. So, maybe this is the affirmation you need to hear at the end of a cruel day.

Here's to survivors everywhere. Our traumas may be different; but loss, regardless of the form, is always traumatic . . . and, yet, we survive. Amen.

Today Means Amen

(Pg 91-93) Dear you,

Whoever you are,

However you got here,

This is exactly where you are supposed to be.

This moment has waited its whole life for you,

You are a solider,

Come home baby, it's over,
You don't need to suffer anymore.

Dear you,
This moment is a surprise party,
You are both hiding in the dark,
And walking through the door,
This moment is a Hallelujah,
This moment is your permission slip,
To finally open that love letter,
You've been hiding from yourself,
The one you wrote when you were little,
When you still danced like a sparkler at dusk,
Do you remember the moment you realized they were watching?
When you became ashamed of how much light you were holding?
When you first learned how to un-love yourself?

Dear you,
The word today, means amen in every language.
Today, we made it,

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Today, I'm gonna love you,
Today, the box cutter will rust in the garbage,
Today, the noose will forget how to hold you,
Today,
Today.

Dear you,
And I have always meant, you.
Nothing would be the same if you did not exist.
You, who were once as small as a bouquet,
Who could sleep in the laughs of strangers,
Nothing would be the same if you did not exist.
You, who's voice is someone's favorite voice,
Someone's favorite face to wake up to,
Nothing would be the same if you did not exist.

You, the teacher,
The starter's gun,
The lantern in the night who offers not a way home,
But the courage to travel farther into the dark.

You, the friend,

The sacred chorus of 'How can I help you?'

Who have felt more numb than holy,

More cracked than mosaic,

Who has known the tiles of a bathroom by heart,

Who has forgotten what makes you worth it.

You, the forgiven,

The forgiver,

Who belongs right here, in this moment.

You, this clump of cells,

This happy explosion that happened to start breathing,

And by the grace of whatever is up there,

You got here,

You made it, this whole way,

Through the nights that swallowed you whole,

The mornings that arrived in pieces,

The scabs, the gravel,

The doubt, the hurt,

The hurt, the hurt,

Is over today,

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You made it,

You made it,

You made it,

Here.

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